A Minor

Scale Practice Worksheet · No sharps, no flats · Relative minor of C major · 4 octaves

A note on minor scales

Practice the harmonic and melodic forms, not just the natural minor. The natural minor sounds identical to C major starting from A — the raised tones are what give minor scales their character and their technical value.

SCALES

01 **Harmonic Minor — Parallel Motion**

Play A harmonic minor up and down in parallel motion (both hands moving in the same direction). The harmonic minor raises the 7th degree: G becomes G♯.

TIP
A minor feels comfortable because the G♯ gives the fingers a black-key landmark, making hand position more natural than all-white-key scales. Start slow, prioritize evenness over speed.

02 **Harmonic Minor — Contrary Motion**

Play A harmonic minor with hands moving in opposite directions — one ascending, one descending simultaneously.

TIP
Harder than parallel motion. Excellent brain training. Add contrary motion to any exercise below for an extra challenge.

03 Melodic Minor — Parallel Motion

Play A melodic minor up and down in parallel motion.

Ascending: Raise both the 6th and 7th degrees — F becomes F♯, G becomes G♯.

Descending: Remove all sharps and descend as natural A minor (**A – G – F – E – D – C – B – A**).

> **TIP**
> This asymmetry is what makes the melodic minor uniquely valuable for training.

04 Melodic Minor — Contrary Motion

Play A melodic minor in contrary motion.

> **ADVANCED VARIATION**
> In contrary motion, one hand plays the melodic form (with sharps) while the other simultaneously plays the natural form (without sharps). Two different patterns happening at the same time — then reverse which hand plays which. This is harder than major-scale contrary motion because the ascending and descending forms differ.

05 Scale in Thirds

Play the A minor scale in intervals of a third — two notes a third apart, played together or in succession.

> **TIP**
> Thirds immediately expose left-hand weakness. If the left hand feels slower than the right, isolate it. Always listen to your left hand and accommodate the right hand to match it — not the other way around.

06 Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply these to any scale exercise for fluidity and evenness:

Quarter accent — every note — extra weight on each individual note.

Eighth accent — every second note — grouped, rolling feel.

Sixteenth accent — every fourth note — builds longer phrase shapes.

Triplet groupings — organize the scale in groups of three.

> **TIP**
> Try these with the harmonic minor in particular — the G# changes the physical feel of each grouping. Stay relaxed. This is your warm-up. You should be very comfortable, not tense.

07 Scale in Tenths (Triplets)

Play the scale in tenths (octave + third between hands) using triplet rhythm. A tenth is simply a third plus an octave — the right hand plays one octave higher than the third position.

> **TIP**
> Significantly harder. Practice ascending and descending. Try it with both harmonic and melodic minor forms.

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — TONIC

08 Arpeggios

Play **A – C – E** broken triads across 4 octaves, with inversions.

Fingering (root position): `RH 1-2-3-1-2-3-5` `LH 5-4-2-1-4-2-1`

Fingering (1st inversion, C–E–A): `RH 1-2-4-1-2-4-5` `LH 5-4-2-1-4-2-1`

Fingering (2nd inversion, E–A–C): `RH 1-2-4-1-2-4-5` `LH 5-4-2-1-4-2-1`

> **TECHNIQUE**
> Feel the natural weight of your arm dropping into the keys. Move in circular motions — stay grounded and free, not rigid. Increase speed gradually.

09 Broken Chords

Play the tonic chord in broken form across the keyboard. A broken chord rearranges the chord tones out of sequential order, jumping between intervals rather than climbing straight through them.

Root position pattern: **A – E – C – A – E – C – A – E** (repeating across octaves)

Fingering (root position): RH 1-5-3-1-5-3 LH 5-1-3-5-1-3

> **TIP**
> If uncomfortable, practice left hand separately first. The left hand naturally wants to lean right on the keyboard — be aware of this pull.

10 Chords

Play solid chords (all notes struck together), with inversions, across three or more octaves.

Warm-up method: First play just the octave (A to A). Then add the middle voices (C, E) one at a time. This activates the inner fingers while the octave frame stays stable.

> **TECHNIQUE**
> Listen to the inner voices — many players only hear the top note. Train yourself to hear and activate the middle voices. Prepare every chord: the moment you play one chord, immediately jump and position for the next. This trains the muscles between thumb and fifth finger. If full chords are too difficult or your hand is smaller, play with smaller three-note chords. Start slow, then gradually increase speed — some burn is normal and good.

11 **Long Arpeggios**

Extended arpeggios across the full keyboard. Root position, 1st inversion, 2nd inversion. Add contrary motion.

Fingering (root position, extended): `RH 1-2-3-1-2-3-1-2-3-1-2-3-5` `LH 5-4-2-1-4-2-1-4-2-1-4-2-1`

Practice method: Separate hands first — this exposes weaknesses you hide when both hands play together. Excellent exercise for training the thumb crossing.

TECHNIQUE

Solid chords train you to grab and strengthen. Long arpeggios train you to loosen up and transfer your arm weight into the keyboard for a full, beautiful sound. Play as legato as possible. Always think about preparation — position the hand for the next shape before you arrive.

SIX-CHORD ARPEGGIOS

12 **Long Six-Chord Arpeggios**

Play extended arpeggios through a cycle of six chords in sequence. This builds endurance and trains rapid hand-shape changes across the keyboard.

The six-chord formula for A minor:

1) **A major** — I (tonic major, root position)

2) **A minor** — i (tonic minor, root position)

3) **F major** — VI (1st inversion — "sixth chord")

4) **F♯ minor** — ♯vi (1st inversion)

5) **D major** — IV (2nd inversion — "six-four chord")

6) **D minor** — iv (2nd inversion)

TIP

The roman numeral pattern is always I – i – VI – ♯vi – IV – iv. This formula works in any key — just build the same relationships from the new tonic. Play each chord as a long arpeggio across the keyboard, then move immediately to the next. Position your thumb and hand shape for the next chord while still finishing the current one. Once you feel the muscles start to burn, the exercise is doing its job.

DOMINANT — E7

13 E7 Exercises (Arpeggios, Broken Chords, Chords, Long Arpeggios)

Repeat exercises 8–11 using **E – G♯ – B – D** (V7 of A minor). Play through all inversions: root, 1st, 2nd, 3rd.

Warm-up: Octave first, then add three middle voices — even more stretch than tonic.

> TIP
> Bigger hand stretch (4 notes). Don't play these at the start of warm-up — hands need to be loose first. Apply rhythmic variations from Exercise 6.

FINISHING

14 Diminished — G♯ dim

Built on the 7th degree of A harmonic minor: **G♯ – B – D** (all minor thirds). Apply the same arpeggio and chord exercises. To be expanded in later sessions.

15 Chromatic Scale

Play the chromatic scale starting from A across the full keyboard. A good way to close out your session.

> VARIATION
> Play the chromatic scale in tenths instead of octaves for increased difficulty. Focus on keeping both hands even — don't let one hand rush ahead of the other.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Always play in 4 octaves for serious practice
- Start slow, increase tempo gradually
- Practice left hand separately — it's almost always weaker
- The right hand covers for left hand imperfections — separate-hand practice exposes the truth
- Use contrary motion to make any exercise harder
- Sit at the edge of the bench for weight transfer
- Engage the upper back for tone, not just the arms
- Don't tense up — this is a warm-up, stay comfortable
- Apply rhythmic variations for evenness training
- Listen to the inner voices — much of music happens in the middle
- Solid chords build strength; long arpeggios build fluidity — both matter
- Be creative with variations — scales practice works best with variety within structure